2.3 Life Under Slavery

After days of hard work, enslaved Africans gathered together—sometimes secretly—on Sundays. They cooked African foods and played music based on African rhythms. As much as they could, they hung on to pieces of their past.

MAIN IDEA Plantation slaves kept their African culture and traditions alive, even though their living and working conditions were often very difficult.

LIVING CONDITIONS

As you've read, most plantation slaves—both men and women—spent long hours planting, weeding, and harvesting tobacco, rice, and indigo. Overseers sometimes used whips and other harsh instruments and measures to force workers to work harder or more productively. Some owners also recruited slaves, called drivers, to push their fellow workers to pick up the pace.

Work in the slaveowner's household was sometimes less brutal. Both men and women cooked and did gardening chores. Women often took care of the children as well. Some men became **artisans**, or skilled workers who crafted things by hand. Some women served as nurses and weavers.

Marriage between slaves was illegal in the colonies. An enslaved couple had to obtain their master's permission to live together as husband and wife. Slave marriages were torn apart when

Slave Housing

Only nine of the 27 slave houses that once stood at Boone Hall Plantation near Charleston, South Carolina, still remain. The houses together make up what is called a "slave street." The nine houses, five of which appear in this photograph, were home to the servants at the plantation house. Each house was divided into two rooms and had either a dirt or a wooden floor. Dirt floors were common in the houses provided for slaves.



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one of the pair was sold to a different slaveowner. In those cases, slaves often walked long distances at night to visit and hold the family together.

Slaves often built their own houses, which were typically one-room cabins. Many planters provided only basic foods for their enslaved workers, such as corn and a little pork. Enslaved people often planted gardens with vegetables like yams and squash to enhance their diet. They also raised hogs and chickens and hunted and fished for extra food.

People from different parts of West Africa often found themselves thrown together on large plantations. To speak to each other, they blended African languages with English. By this means, such African words as *yam* and *tote* were introduced into the English language.

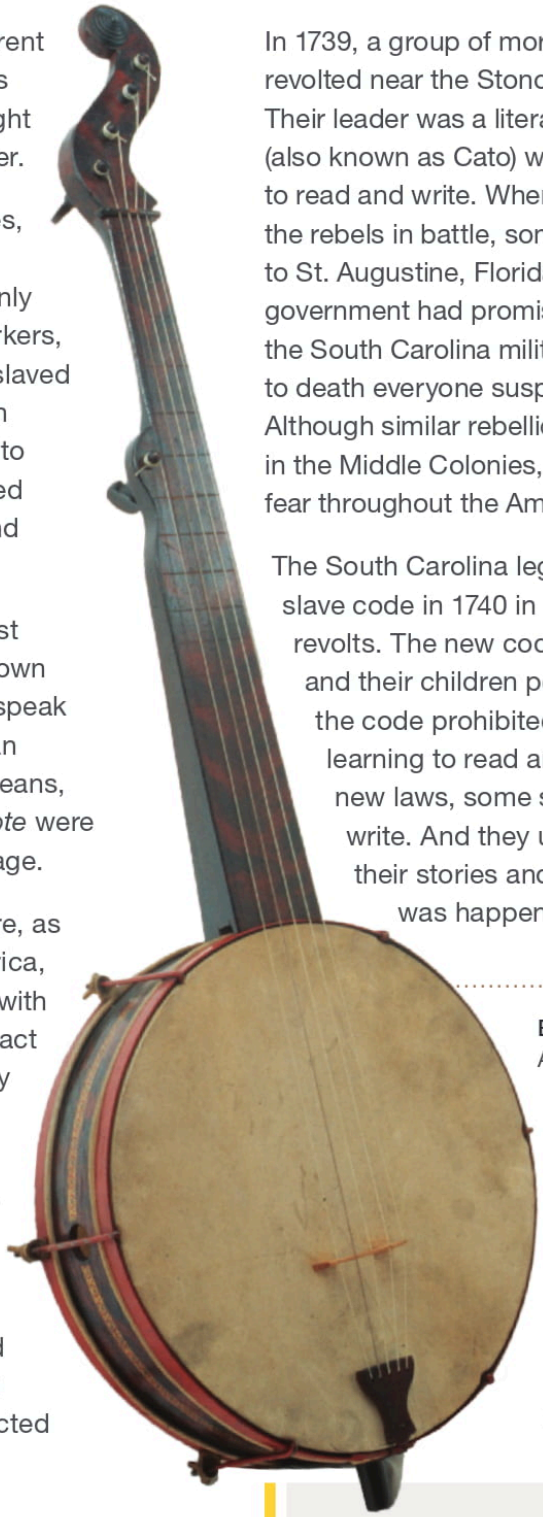
Africans influenced colonial culture, as well as that of early national America, in many other ways. Their music, with its rhythmic beat, had a huge impact on jazz and blues. They made clay pottery, baskets, and musical instruments with African designs. They also popularized new foods, including okra, melons, and bananas. In Boston, a slave taught his owner the practice of vaccination, which he had learned in Africa. As a result of the slave's help, the city's people were protected from a smallpox outbreak.

ACTS OF REBELLION

Enslaved people did what they could to cope with their situation, but many actively rebelled against their treatment. They resisted the slave owner's power by staging slowdowns, faking illness, and secretly destroying crops and tools. Others ran away. Some enslaved people became violent, killing the slave owners or setting fire to fields and homes.

In 1739, a group of more than 50 enslaved people revolted near the Stono River in South Carolina. Their leader was a literate slave named Jemmy (also known as Cato) whose master had taught him to read and write. When armed planters defeated the rebels in battle, some of the slaves headed to St. Augustine, Florida, where the Spanish government had promised them freedom. But the South Carolina militia pursued them, putting to death everyone suspected of being involved. Although similar rebellions had already taken place in the Middle Colonies, the **Stono Rebellion** sent fear throughout the American colonies.

The South Carolina legislature enacted a harsh slave code in 1740 in an effort to prevent future revolts. The new code made all enslaved people and their children permanent slaves. In addition, the code prohibited enslaved people from learning to read and write. In spite of these new laws, some slaves did learn to read and write. And they used this knowledge to tell their stories and let the world know what was happening to them.



Banjo
Africans on plantations played instruments made of a gourd cut in half with a goatskin stretched over it, a stick, and three strings. The banjo shown here was made in Baltimore, Maryland, in 1845. In this banjo, the gourd has been replaced with a circular wooden frame and the stick with a flat piece of wood. In other modern versions, the frame is sometimes made of metal.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What measures did owners use to force slaves to work harder?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What are some of the ways in which enslaved people asserted their humanity and kept their traditions alive?
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What were the long-term negative consequences of the Stono Rebellion on enslaved people?

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